

Fifty Years of Gender Bias

When it comes to hiring decisions, people vastly overestimate how much gender bias there is - against both sexes



STEVE STEWART-WILLIAMS

NOV 11, 2023



19



7

Share



How much gender bias is there in hiring decisions? Has gender bias in hiring decisions declined over the last half-century? And how accurate are people's beliefs about levels of gender bias in hiring decisions? These are some of the questions that inspired a fascinating

new book by Michael C. H. Williams and colleagues, published in the journal *Organizational*

new [paper](#) by Michael Schaefer and colleagues, published in the journal *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*.

The Studies

The paper reported on two related studies. The first was a pre-registered meta-analysis of field studies looking at gender bias in hiring decisions. Field studies are studies where fake job applications are submitted to real companies, with everything about the applications held constant except the variable of interest - in this case, the sex of the applicant. By counting the number of callbacks received for female vs. male applications, researchers can measure ambient levels of gender bias. Schaefer and colleagues set out to meta-analyze all the field studies they could get their hands on - that is, to combine them all into one giant study. They ended up with 85 studies spanning 26 countries, 44 years, and nearly 400,000 fake applications. The studies covered male-dominated professions (e.g., engineer, truck driver), female-dominated professions (e.g., HR professional, nurse), and gender-balanced professions (e.g., graphic designer, lab worker).

Schaefer and colleagues' second study was a forecasting survey. The researchers asked a large group of people - both laypeople and academics - to predict the results of the meta-analysis prior to crunching the numbers. (Full disclosure: I was one of the people comparing the predictions to the actual results, Schaefer and co. of people's beliefs about gender bias in hiring.

The Findings

The results were fascinating and surprising. Starting with the male-dominated and gender-balanced fields, Schaefer and colleagues found significant bias in hiring in the mid-1970s, which declined steadily over the next few decades and had almost evaporated by 2009. A tentative exploratory analysis suggested that there was a small bias in favor of gender bias in male-dominated fields and a small bias in favor of gender-balanced fields.



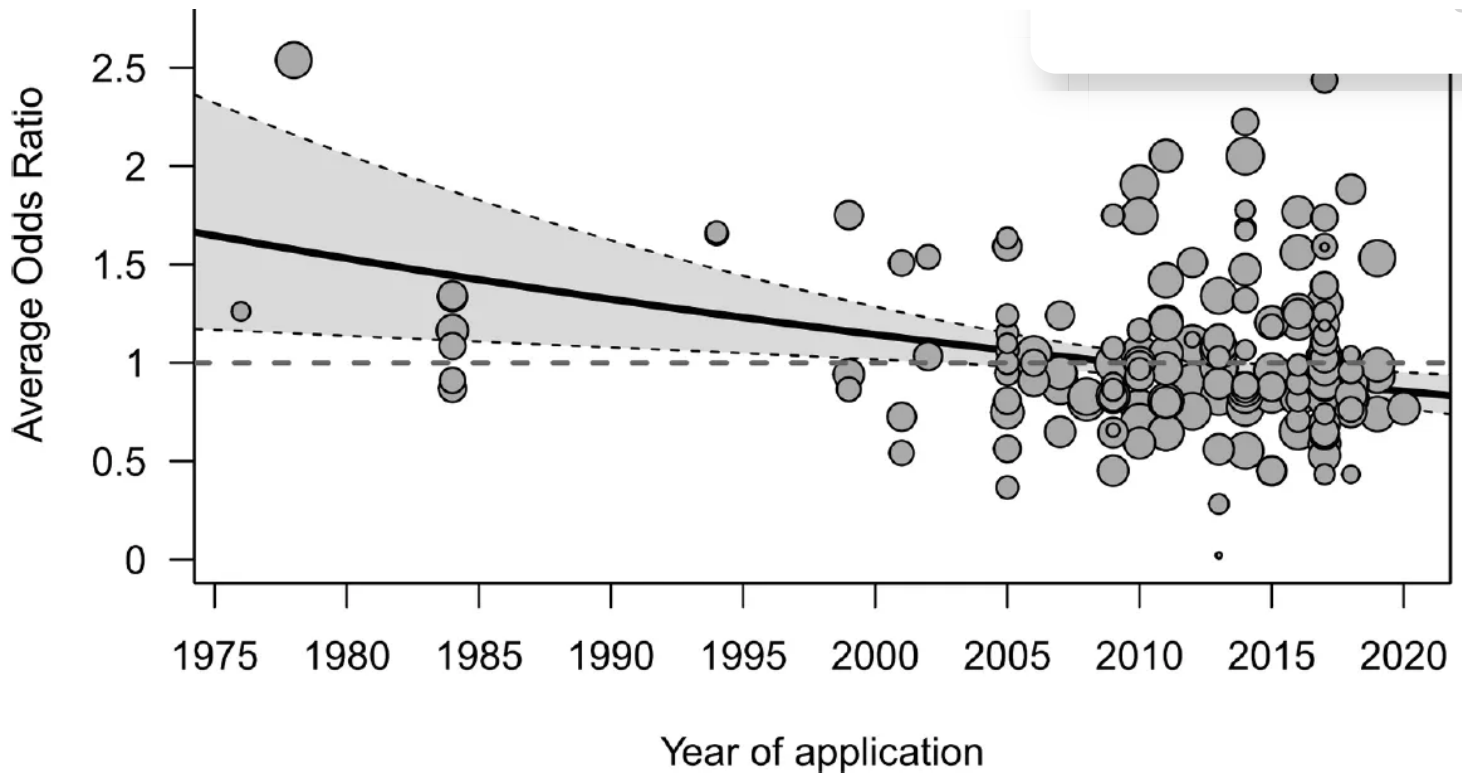
Discover more from The News

The newsletter of Professor
Psychology, evolution, science

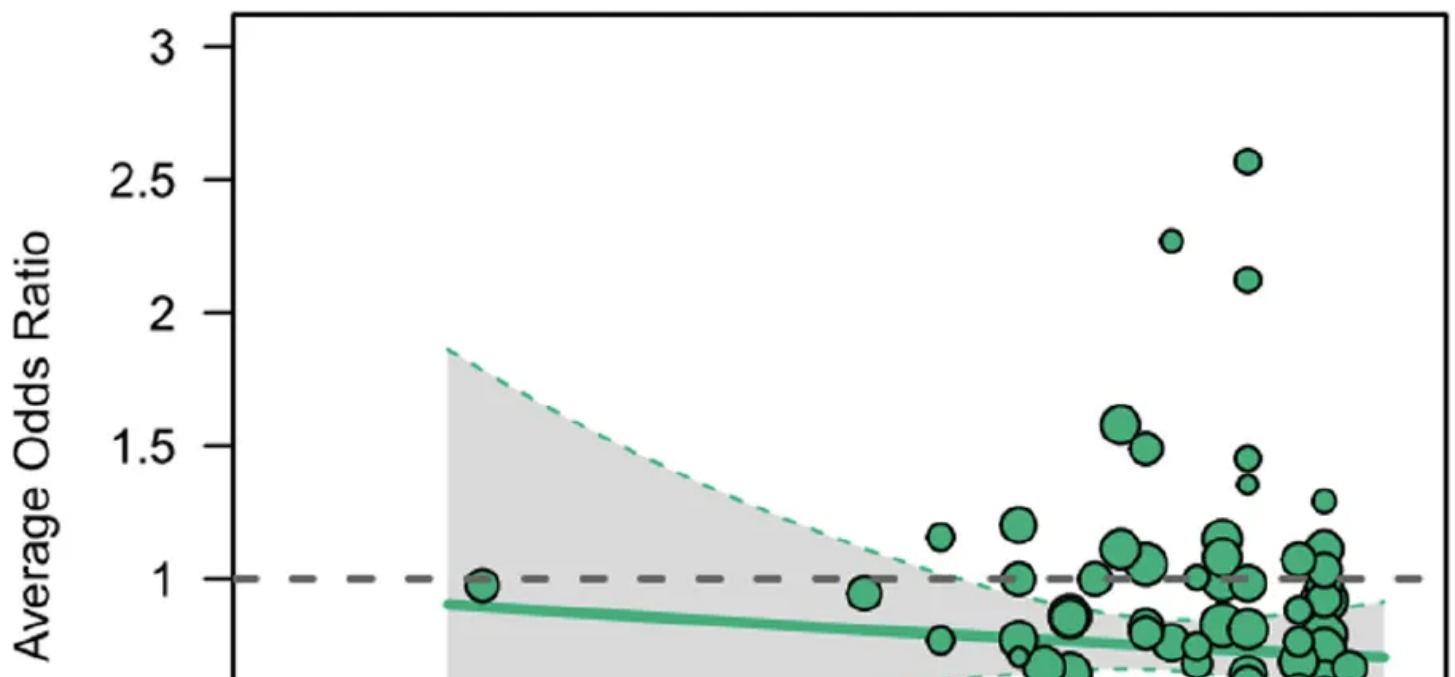
Subscribe

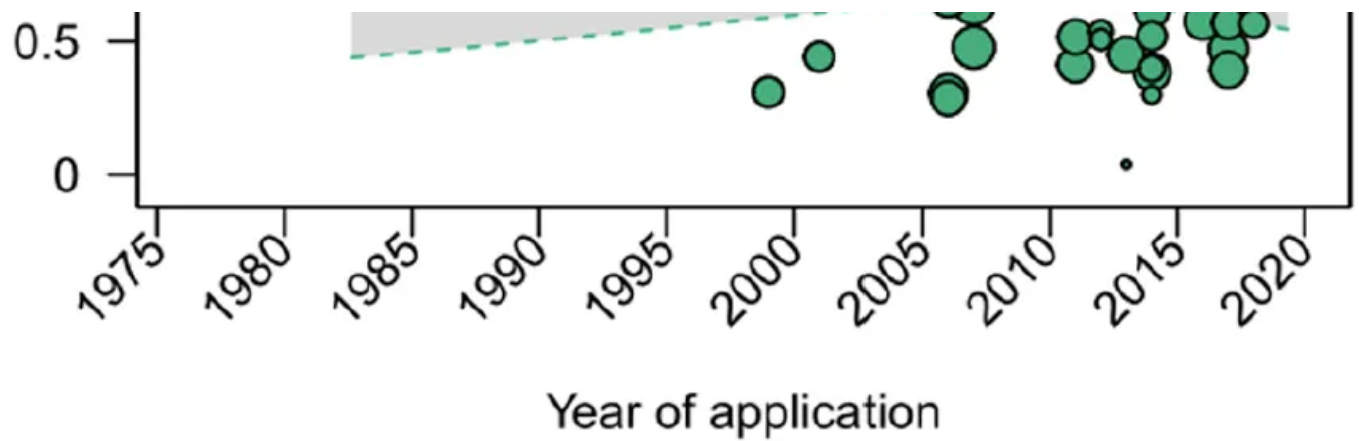
Continue reading

Sign up

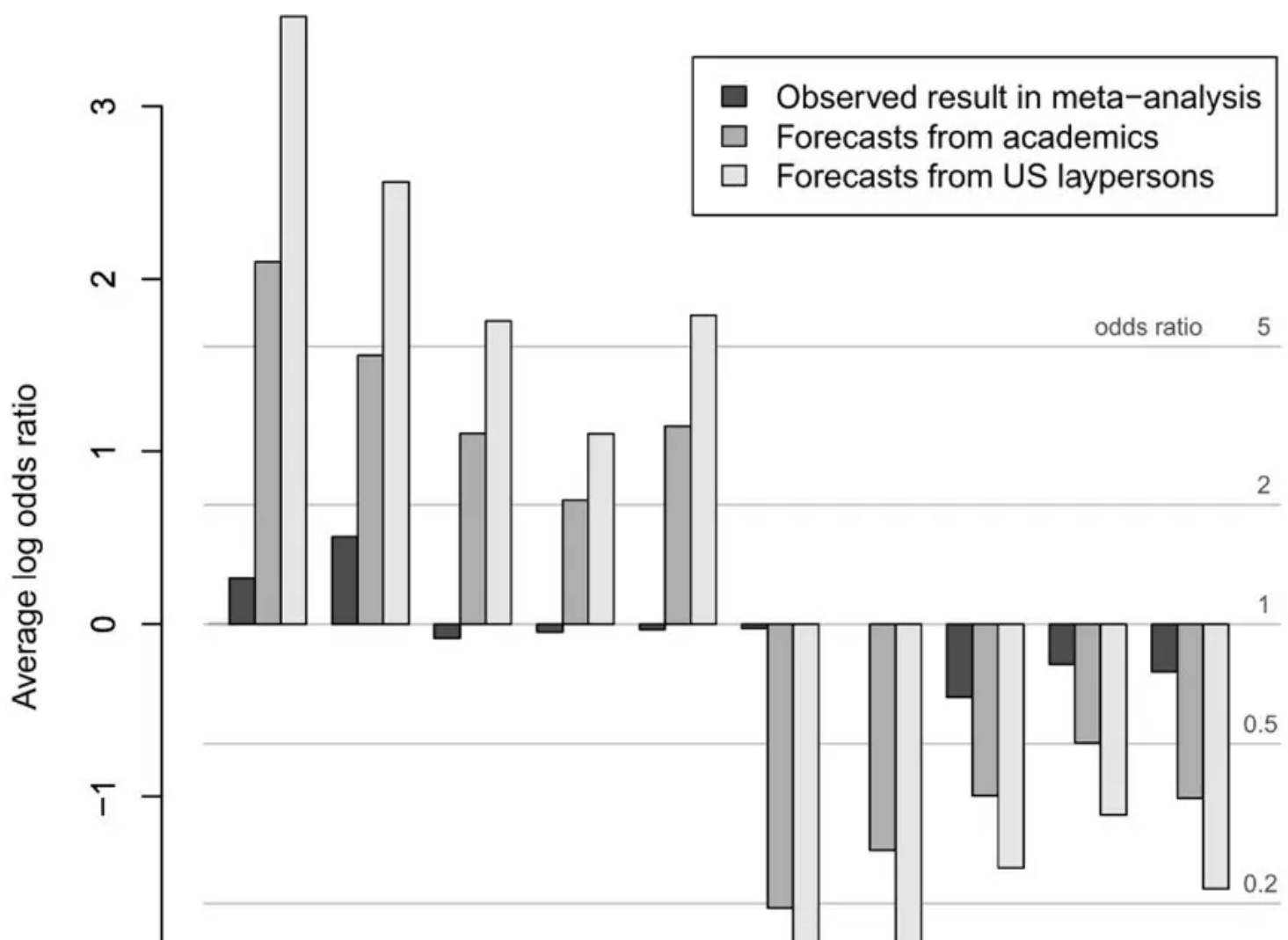


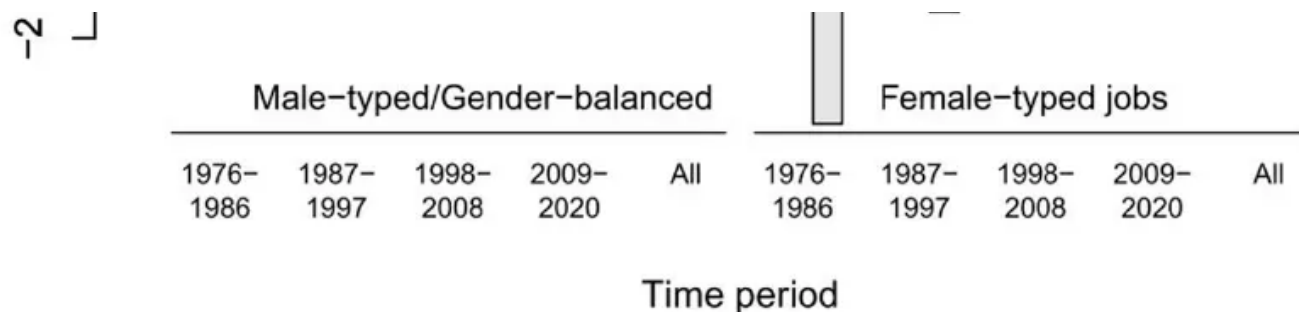
For the female-dominated fields, the picture was very different. Female applicants were consistently favored in those fields from the mid-1970s till today, with no evidence of meaningful change in the level of bias over that period. So, whereas pro-male bias receded, pro-female bias basically flatlined.





On to Study 2: How accurate were the forecasters' estimates of levels of bias over time? The short answer is the following figure. Note that scores above 0 indicate bias in favor of males, whereas scores below 0 indicate the reverse.





The most striking finding in the figure is the fact that the forecasters overestimated - massively overestimated - levels of gender bias in callback rates. They overestimated how much gender bias women face in male-dominated and gender-balanced fields, and they overestimated how much gender bias *men* face in female-dominated fields. And although laypeople overestimated gender bias to a greater extent than academics, laypeople and academics alike were extremely inaccurate in their estimates. At least in this domain, the world is apparently nowhere near as bad as people think it is.

To be fair, the forecasters did correctly predict that gender bias against women had receded since the 1970s. Still, their estimates of present-day gender bias were much higher than the actual levels of bias even in the sexist 70s. And although forecasters correctly predicted the decline in bias against women, they also *incorrectly* predicted a parallel decline in bias against men - a decline that was nowhere to be found in the data.

A few other juicy findings: Experts on gender and gender stereotyping were no more accurate in their estimates than non-experts. And the more committed that forecasters were to gender egalitarianism, the more they overestimated levels of gender bias!

What It All Means

Overall, the news is good. Efforts to reduce bias against women in hiring have been remarkably successful. When we put our minds to it, we can root out gender bias - and we can do so relatively quickly. But although we've made good progress in reducing hiring bias against women, we haven't done the same for men. Men, it seems, are just as likely to face gender bias in female-dominated fields as they were in the 1970s. That said, however, neither sex is anywhere near as likely to face gender bias as most people apparently believe.

Long story short, the Schaerer et al. paper is an excellent and important contribution to the scientific literature on gender bias. I hope it gets the attention it deserves!

Thanks for reading The Nature-Nurture-
Nietzsche Newsletter! Subscribe for free to
receive new posts and support my work.



19 Likes · 5 Restacks

7 Comments



Write a comment...



Plato's Rabbit Cave Writes Plato's Rabbit Cave Nov 17

Can someone explain what 'bias' means in this context? Is it the same as preference? Or choice? Or calculated decision?

If an employer hires only female ditch diggers is that an example of gender bias or an actual preference for female ditch diggers? Surely bias (in the strict sense of the word) can only be measured against a control group of anonymous applications which have been stripped of gender markers, so that gender itself can be isolated from other factors (qualifications, experience, ability, physical strength etc)?

Is there a study into men and women's biases when it comes to what jobs they choose to apply for? Surely that is the other half of the equation which needs considering?

If most ditch digging applicants are female then all the protective clothing will be a female fit, and the culture will be very female orientated. A male applicant will require specialist clothing and safety equipment, his own changing rooms etc. This will add cost to the business and make that applicant less viable.

Also women don't pay taxes, only men do (when you subtract tax spending from tax contributions women end up with a net benefit and men a net deficit). Men's increased financial burdens and women's financial subsidy has a HUGE impact on the kinds of jobs men and women tend to apply for.... and presumably this in turn influences employment decisions too.

In simple terms men need the money more than women, because women have men to subsidise them but men get no subsidy from women (women are a financial burden to men).

I don't see how this study has any meaning or relevance without this kind of context.

♡ LIKE 💬 REPLY ↗ SHARE

...



Jean Nov 12

"Efforts to reduce bias against women in hiring have been remarkably successful."

Not so fast. There is no evidence in this paper to support this. An alternative hypothesis is that people have become less prejudice over time for other reasons. Yet another is that so-called reverse discrimination is evening out the trends.

♡ LIKE 💬 REPLY ↗ SHARE

...

5 more comments...

